# ALMOST ALL LOOPS HAVE MULTIPLICATION GROUP $S_n$

Abstract. Cameron proved that for almost all quasigroups of order $n$ the left translations generate the symmetric or the alternating group, and Häggkvist and Janssen excluded the alternating group; Cameron asked whether the same holds for loops, where the argument breaks because the translation by the identity is trivial. We show that it does, by counting: the probability that the rows of a uniformly random reduced Latin square of order $n$ generate a group not containing $A_n$ is at most $e^{-(\log 2-o(1))n^2}$, and the group is $S_n$ with probability $1-O(c^n)$ for some $c<1$. The inputs are the van der Waerden and Brégman bounds on the number of Latin squares, the elementary bounds of Babai and Pyber on the orders of primitive groups, and the Häggkvist–Janssen bound on Latin squares all of whose rows are even permutations; the classification of finite simple groups is not used. This settles the question, raised by Cameron and recorded by Cavenagh, Greenhill and Wanless as a consequence of their conjecture on the second row, and completes an argument sketched by Eberhard in 2016.

## 1. Introduction

Let $Q$ be a quasigroup of order $n$ on the set $[n]=\{1,\dots,n\}$, with Cayley table a Latin square $L$, and for $x\in Q$ let $L_x\colon y\mapsto xy$ be the left translation, the $x$-th row of $L$ read as a permutation of $[n]$. The *left multiplication group* $\mathrm{Mlt}_\lambda(Q)=\langle L_x : x\in Q\rangle$ is a transitive subgroup of $S_n$, and the full multiplication group $\mathrm{Mlt}(Q)$, generated by all left and right translations, contains it. Cameron [3] showed that for almost all quasigroups (that is, for all but a vanishing proportion of the Latin squares of order $n$) the left translations generate $S_n$ or $A_n$; Häggkvist and Janssen [7] then showed that the proportion of Latin squares all of whose rows are even permutations is at most $c^n$ for some $c<1$, so that $A_n$ occurs for a proportion at most $c^n$ of quasigroups. In particular $\mathrm{Mlt}(Q)$ is 2-transitive, which in Smith's character theory of quasigroups [17] means that almost all quasigroups have trivial character theory ("rank 2").

Cameron's argument is short. A uniformly random Latin square has a uniformly random first row, and by a theorem of Łuczak and Pyber [10] a uniformly random permutation lies in no transitive proper subgroup of $S_n$ other than $A_n$ with probability $1-o(1)$; since the rows generate a transitive group, that group contains $A_n$.

For *loops* — quasigroups with an identity element, whose Cayley tables, suitably labelled, are the *reduced* Latin squares, with first row and first column in natural order — the argument is not available: the first row is the identity permutation, and no other row is uniformly distributed. Cameron asked whether almost all loops nevertheless have multiplication group $S_n$ (see [4], and [5, §6], where Cavenagh, Greenhill and Wanless record, as Lemma 6.2, that this follows from their conjecture on the cycle structure of the second row of a random Latin square). The statement is folklore in loop theory, where it is mentioned as an unproved belief. The purpose of this note is to settle it, by an argument that uses no information about the second row at all.

**Theorem 1.** *Let $L$ be a uniformly random reduced Latin square of order $n$ and $H(L)\le S_n$ the group generated by its rows. Then*

$$\mathbb{P}\big[H(L)\not\supseteq A_n\big]\le e^{-(\log 2-o(1))n^2},\qquad \text{and}\qquad \mathbb{P}\big[H(L)=S_n\big]\ge 1-3c^n$$

*for some absolute $c<1$ and all large $n$. Consequently almost all loops have $\mathrm{Mlt}_\lambda(Q)=\mathrm{Mlt}(Q)=S_n$ and trivial character theory.*

*Date*: October 2026 — draft.

(The first row of a reduced square is the identity, so $H(L)$ is the left multiplication group of the loop. For a square with arbitrary first row $r_1$ the group that matters is $\langle r_1^{-1}r_i\rangle$, the row group of the loop whose Cayley table is obtained by relabelling the symbols and then reordering the rows; this is set out in §2, and it is in the larger set of squares with first row the identity that the counting is done.)

The idea, which Eberhard sketched in comments on Cameron's post [4], is that the event is about all $n-1$ non-identity rows simultaneously, and such events are cheap to bound by counting: for a subgroup $K \le S_n$, at most $|K|^{n-1}$ of the $L(n)/n! = (n!)^{n-1}e^{-n^2+o(n^2)}$ Latin squares with first row the identity have all their rows in $K$, a proportion of at most $e^{n^2+o(n^2)}/[S_n : K]^{n-1}$, which is $e^{-\delta n^2+o(n^2)}$ as soon as $[S_n : K] \ge e^{(1+\delta)n}$. A transitive proper subgroup lies in a maximal one, and the maximal transitive subgroups of $S_n$ are the wreath products $S_a \wr S_b$, $ab = n$, of which there are fewer than $n \cdot n!$, and the primitive maximal subgroups. The crude count disposes of $S_a \wr S_b$ for $b \ge 3$ (the index $n!/((a!)^b b!)$ is a multinomial coefficient over $b!$, at least $3^n/n^{O(1)}$) but not of $S_{n/2} \wr S_2$ (index $\binom{n}{n/2}/2 < e^n$) nor of $A_n$; for the primitive subgroups one needs a bound on their orders strong enough that their number does not matter. We handle every imprimitive group by a single block decomposition (Lemma 2), which is sharper than the crude count — for $b = 3$ the crude count gives $e^{-(\log 3-1)n^2+o(n^2)}$ and for $b = 2$ nothing, while the lemma gives $e^{-(\log 2-o(1))n^2}$ for every $b$ — and in particular disposes of $S_{n/2} \wr S_2$; the primitive groups by the elementary order bounds of Babai and Pyber, after which their number is controlled by counting generators; and $A_n$ by the theorem of Häggkvist and Janssen. No step uses the classification of finite simple groups.

## 2. Preliminaries

Latin squares. Let $\mathcal{L}_n$ be the set of Latin squares of order $n$ on the symbol set $[n]$ and $L(n) = |\mathcal{L}_n|$. We use two classical bounds [19, Ch. 17]: the lower bound $L(n) \ge (n!)^{2n}/n^{n^2}$, a consequence of the van der Waerden permanent inequality applied row by row, and the upper bound $L(n) \le \prod_{k=1}^{n}(k!)^{n/k}$, a consequence of Brégman's. In the explicit forms we need,

$$\log L(n) \ge n^2 \log n - 2n^2, \qquad \log L(a) \le a^2 \log a - 2a^2 + a\big(\tfrac{1}{2}\log^2 a + 2\log a + 3\big) \tag{1}$$

for all $n, a \ge 1$. The first follows from $n! \ge (n/e)^n$. For the second, $\log k! \le k\log k - k + \log k + 1$ for $k \ge 1$ gives $(\log k!)/k \le \log k - 1 + (\log k + 1)/k$, and summing over $k \le a$ with $\log a! \le a\log a - a + \log a + 1$, $\sum_{k\le a}(\log k)/k \le \frac{1}{2}\log^2 a + 1$ and $\sum_{k\le a} 1/k \le \log a + 1$,

$$\sum_{k=1}^{a} \frac{\log k!}{k} \le a\log a - 2a + \tfrac{1}{2}\log^2 a + 2\log a + 3,$$

which multiplied by $a$ is the claim.

Loops and reduced squares. Three sets of squares are counted below: $\mathcal{L}_n$; the squares with first row the identity, $\mathcal{L}_n^0 := \{L \in \mathcal{L}_n : r_1 = \mathrm{id}\}$; and the reduced squares, whose first row and first column are the identity, $R(n)$ in number. Relabelling the symbols of $L \in \mathcal{L}_n$ by a permutation is a bijection of $\mathcal{L}_n$ (there are $n!$ of them), permuting the rows is another ($n!$ of them), and

$$|\mathcal{L}_n^0| = \frac{L(n)}{n!}, \qquad R(n) = \frac{|\mathcal{L}_n^0|}{(n-1)!} = \frac{L(n)}{n!\,(n-1)!}\,: \tag{2}$$

exactly one relabelling of the symbols (by $r_1^{-1}$, where $r_1, \dots, r_n \in S_n$ are the rows of $L$, $r_i(c) = L(i,c)$) brings the first row to the identity, giving the square $L^0$ with rows $\sigma_i = r_1^{-1}r_i$; and exactly one permutation of the rows of $L^0$ fixing the first row (which is the unique row with entry 1 in column 1) brings the first column to $1, 2, \dots, n$, giving a reduced square with the same

*set* of rows as $L^0$. A uniform reduced square is the Cayley table of a uniform random loop on $[n]$ with identity 1, whose left translations are its rows. Writing

$$H(L) := \langle \sigma_2, \dots, \sigma_n \rangle = \langle r_1^{-1} r_i : 2 \le i \le n \rangle \le S_n,$$

relabelling the symbols of $L$ by $\tau$ replaces each $r_i$ by $\tau r_i$ and leaves every $r_1^{-1} r_i = (\tau r_1)^{-1}(\tau r_i)$, hence $H(L)$, unchanged; so for every subgroup $K \le S_n$ the proportion of $L \in \mathcal{L}_n$ with $H(L) = K$ equals the proportion of $L^0 \in \mathcal{L}_n^0$ with $H(L^0) = K$, equals the proportion of reduced squares with row group $K$, equals the proportion of loops $Q$ of order $n$ with $\mathrm{Mlt}_\lambda(Q) = K$. It therefore suffices to prove the bounds of Theorem 1 for $H(L)$ as proportions of $\mathcal{L}_n^0$, which is what we do. Two further facts. First, $H(L)$ is transitive: the first column of $L$ is a permutation, so the values $\sigma_i(1) = r_1^{-1}(L(i,1))$, $1 \le i \le n$, run through all of $[n]$. Second, for a subgroup $K \le S_n$ the squares $L \in \mathcal{L}_n$ all of whose rows lie in $K$ are exactly the relabellings by $\tau \in K$ of the squares $L^0 \in \mathcal{L}_n^0$ all of whose rows lie in $K$ (if $r_1 \in K$ then $r_i \in K$ iff $\sigma_i \in K$), $|K|$ of them for each $L^0$; dividing by $L(n) = n!\,|\mathcal{L}_n^0|$,

$$\mathbb{P}_{\mathcal{L}_n^0}\big[H \le K\big] = \frac{n!}{|K|}\,\mathbb{P}_{\mathcal{L}_n}\big[\text{all rows in } K\big], \tag{3}$$

where $\mathbb{P}_X$ denotes proportion in $X$. The two sides differ by the index of $K$, which is where a count of squares with all rows in $K$ (as in Lemma 2) and a statement about $H$ part company.

Group theory. We use three facts about subgroups of $S_n$. A transitive subgroup not containing $A_n$ is either imprimitive, i.e. contained in the stabiliser $\mathrm{Stab}(\Pi) \cong S_a \wr S_b$ of a partition $\Pi$ of $[n]$ into $b$ blocks of size $a$ with $1 < a < n$, or primitive. A primitive subgroup $K \not\supseteq A_n$ has order at most

$$B := e^{4\sqrt{n}\log^2 n} \qquad \text{for } n \ge n_0.$$

Indeed, if $K$ is uniprimitive (primitive but not doubly transitive), $|K| < B$ is Babai's theorem [1]; if $K$ is doubly transitive, $|K| \le \exp(\exp(c\sqrt{\log n}))$ by Babai [2] and $|K| \le n^{c\log^2 n}$ by Pyber [14], and either bound is below $B$ once $n$ is large. The proofs of all three bounds are elementary; in particular they do not use the classification of finite simple groups. Finally a group of order $m$ is generated by at most $\log_2 m$ elements (adjoining to a proper subgroup an element outside it at least doubles the order).

## 3. Proof of Theorem 1

**Lemma 2** (squares with a block structure)**.** *Let $\Pi = \{C_1, \dots, C_b\}$ be a partition of the columns $[n]$ and $\Pi' = \{S_1, \dots, S_b\}$ a partition of the symbols $[n]$, both into $b$ blocks of size $a$, $ab = n$. The number of Latin squares $L \in \mathcal{L}_n$ every row of which maps each block of $\Pi$ onto a block of $\Pi'$ is exactly $T(a,b)\,L(a)^{b^2}$, where $T(a,b) \le (b!)^n$ is the number of $n \times b$ arrays with entries in $[b]$ whose rows are permutations of $[b]$ and in each of whose columns every symbol occurs exactly $a$ times. (Only $\Pi' = \Pi$ is used below; the proof is the same for two partitions.)*

*Proof.* Each row $r_i$ of such a square induces a bijection $\pi_i \colon [b] \to [b]$ with $r_i(C_j) = S_{\pi_i(j)}$. Fix $j, j'$ and let $I_{jj'} = \{i : \pi_i(j) = j'\}$. In a column $c \in C_j$ each of the $a$ symbols of $S_{j'}$ occurs exactly once, and only in rows of $I_{jj'}$, each of which contributes exactly one symbol of $S_{j'}$ to column $c$; hence $|I_{jj'}| = a$, so the array $(\pi_i(j))$ is of the kind counted by $T(a,b)$, and the subarray with rows $I_{jj'}$ and columns $C_j$ is an $a \times a$ Latin square on the symbol set $S_{j'}$. Thus $L$ is determined by the array together with one Latin square of order $a$ for each of the $b^2$ pairs $(j, j')$, on the row set $I_{jj'}$, column set $C_j$ and symbol set $S_{j'}$ determined by the array (identifying each of these sets with $[a]$ in increasing order). Conversely every such array together with any $b^2$ small squares gives a square of the required kind: row $i$ carries, on the column block $C_j$, each symbol of $S_{\pi_i(j)}$ once, and these $b$ symbol blocks are distinct; column $c \in C_j$ carries, on the rows $I_{jj'}$,

each symbol of $S_{j'}$ once, and the $b$ row sets $I_{jj'}$ ($j' \in [b]$) partition $[n]$. There are at most $(b!)^n$ arrays and $L(a)$ choices for each small square. □

*Proof of Theorem 1.* Throughout, $\mathbb{P}$ denotes proportion in $\mathcal{L}_n^0$; by the discussion above, these proportions equal the corresponding proportions of reduced squares, hence of loops. Let $L^0$ be uniform on $\mathcal{L}_n^0$ and $H = H(L^0)$. Since $H$ is transitive, if $H \not\geq A_n$ then $H$ is imprimitive or primitive of order at most $B := e^{4\sqrt{n}\log^2 n}$ (for $n \geq n_0$, by the group-theoretic facts above).

*Imprimitive.* Suppose $H$ preserves a partition $\Pi$ of $[n]$ into $b$ blocks of size $a$, $1 < a < n$. Then every row of $L^0$ maps each block of $\Pi$ onto a block of $\Pi$, so by Lemma 2 with $\Pi' = \Pi$,

$$\mathbb{P}\big[H \leq \mathrm{Stab}(\Pi)\big] \leq \frac{(b!)^n\, L(a)^{b^2}}{L(n)/n!}.$$

There are $n!/((a!)^b b!) \leq n!$ partitions $\Pi$ with blocks of size $a$ and fewer than $n$ divisors $a$ of $n$. By (1), with $b = n/a$, $(b!)^n \leq b^{nb}$ and $\log n! \leq n\log n$ (of the two factors $n!$ below, one is the $n!$ of $|\mathcal{L}_n^0| = L(n)/n!$ and the other bounds the number of partitions),

$$\begin{aligned}\log \frac{n!\cdot n!\,(b!)^n\, L(a)^{b^2}}{L(n)} &\leq 2n\log n + \frac{n^2}{a}\log b + \Big(n^2\log a - 2n^2 + \frac{n^2}{a}\big(\tfrac12\log^2 a + 2\log a + 3\big)\Big)\\ &\quad - n^2\log n + 2n^2\\ &= -n^2\log b + \frac{n^2}{a}\Big(\log b + \tfrac12\log^2 a + 2\log a + 3\Big) + 2n\log n.\end{aligned}$$

If $a \geq \sqrt{n}$, the middle term is at most $n^{3/2}(\frac12\log^2 n + 3\log n + 3) = o(n^2)$, so the right side is $-n^2\log b + o(n^2) \leq -n^2\log 2 + o(n^2)$. If $2 \leq a < \sqrt{n}$, then $b > \sqrt{n}$, $(n^2/a)\log b \leq \frac12 n^2\log b$, and $(\frac12\log^2 a + 2\log a + 3)/a \leq \frac52$ (the function is decreasing in $a \geq 1$, its derivative being $-(\frac12\log^2 a + \log a + 1)/a^2$, and is less than 2.32 at $a = 2$), so the right side is at most $-\frac12 n^2\log b + \frac52 n^2 + 2n\log n \leq -\frac14 n^2\log n + 3n^2$, which is at most $-n^2\log 2$ once $n \geq e^{15}$. Summing over $\Pi$ and $a$,

$$\mathbb{P}[H \text{ imprimitive}] \leq n\, e^{-(\log 2 - o(1))n^2},$$

where the $o(1)$ is $O(\log^2 n/n)$: the term $a = n/2$ is at most $e^{-n^2\log 2 + O(n\log^2 n)}$, every term with $b \geq 3$ and $a \geq \sqrt{n}$ is at most $e^{-n^2\log 3 + O(n^{3/2}\log^2 n)}$, and every term with $a < \sqrt{n}$ is at most $e^{-n^2\log 2}$ for $n \geq e^{15}$, so the sum is at most $n\, e^{-n^2\log 2 + O(n\log^2 n)}$.

*Primitive.* Let $n \geq n_0$. For a fixed subgroup $K \leq S_n$, the squares $L^0 \in \mathcal{L}_n^0$ all of whose rows lie in $K$ number at most $|K|^{n-1}$. A subgroup of order at most $B$ is generated by at most $\log_2 B \leq 6\sqrt{n}\log^2 n$ elements, so there are at most $(n!)^{6\sqrt{n}\log^2 n} \leq e^{6n^{3/2}\log^3 n}$ of them. Summing over these,

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}\big[H \text{ primitive},\ H \not\geq A_n\big] &\leq \frac{e^{6n^{3/2}\log^3 n}\, B^{\,n-1}}{L(n)/n!}\\ &\leq \exp\big(-n^2\log n + 2n^2 + n\log n + 6n^{3/2}\log^3 n + 4n^{3/2}\log^2 n\big)\\ &= e^{-(1-o(1))n^2\log n}.\end{aligned}$$

Adding the two cases gives the first inequality of the theorem.

*The sign.* $H \leq A_n$ if and only if every row $\sigma_i$ of $L^0$ is even. Under the $n!$-to-one map $L \mapsto L^0$ this is the condition that every row $r_i$ of $L \in \mathcal{L}_n$ has the parity of $r_1$, so the proportion of $L^0 \in \mathcal{L}_n^0$ with all rows even equals the proportion of $L \in \mathcal{L}_n$ with all rows of one parity. Relabelling the symbols by a transposition is a bijection of $\mathcal{L}_n$ reversing the parity of every row, so the squares with all rows odd are as many as those with all rows even, and the latter are at most $c^n|\mathcal{L}_n|$ by

Häggkvist and Janssen [7]. Hence $\mathbb{P}[H \le A_n] \le 2c^n$. If $H \supseteq A_n$ and $H \not\le A_n$ then $H = S_n$; so $\mathbb{P}[H \ne S_n] \le e^{-(\log 2 - o(1))n^2} + 2c^n \le 3c^n$ for large $n$. Finally $\mathrm{Mlt}(Q) \supseteq \mathrm{Mlt}_\lambda(Q) = S_n$ is 2-transitive, which is the rank-2 condition of [17]. □

## 4. Remarks

*Remark* 3 (sharpness). The first bound of the theorem is sharp on the scale $n^2$ for even $n$ and not otherwise; more precisely, the proof and the lemma together determine the exponent at every order. Let $n$ be composite with least prime factor $p$ (so $p \le \sqrt{n}$). Then

$$\log \mathbb{P}[H \not\supseteq A_n] = -n^2 \log p + o(n^2),$$

so that $\log \mathbb{P}[H \not\supseteq A_n]/n^2 \to -\log 2$ along even $n$ (no statement about a multiplicative constant is intended) and the exponent $\log 2$ of the theorem is attained there, while for odd composite $n$ the true exponent is $\log p > \log 2$. For the lower bound take the partition $\Pi$ into $p$ blocks of size $a = n/p$: $T(a,p) \ge 1$ (the array in which the rows of the $k$-th block of $a$ rows are the $k$-th row of the cyclic Latin square of order $p$ has every symbol $a$ times in every column), so by Lemma 2 at least $L(a)^{p^2}$ squares of $\mathcal{L}_n$ have all rows in $\mathrm{Stab}(\Pi)$, and by (3) and (1)

$$\mathbb{P}[H \not\supseteq A_n] \ge \mathbb{P}[H \le \mathrm{Stab}(\Pi)] \ge \frac{L(a)^{p^2}}{L(n)} \ge e^{\,p^2(a^2\log a - 2a^2) - n^2\log n + 2n^2 - n(\frac{1}{2}\log^2 n + 2\log n + 3)} = e^{-n^2\log p - O(n\log^2 n)}.$$

For the upper bound, split the imprimitive sum at $a = \log^2 n$ instead of $\sqrt{n}$. Every divisor $b = n/a > 1$ is at least $p$. If $a \ge \log^2 n$, the middle term of the display is at most $n^2 \log n/\log^2 n + n^2(\frac{1}{2}\log^2 a + 2\log a + 3)/a = O(n^2/\log n)$ (the function of $a$ is decreasing), so the term is at most $-n^2\log b + O(n^2/\log n) \le -n^2\log p + O(n^2/\log n)$. If $2 \le a < \log^2 n$, the bound $-\frac{1}{4}n^2\log n + 3n^2$ of the proof applies (for large $n$, so that $\log^2 n < \sqrt{n}$), and it is below $-n^2\log p$ once $\frac{1}{4}\log n - 3 \ge 2\log\log n$, because $\log p \le \log a < 2\log\log n$. The primitive case contributes $e^{-(1-o(1))n^2\log n} \le e^{-n^2\log p - (\frac{1}{2}-o(1))n^2\log n}$. Hence $\mathbb{P}[H \not\supseteq A_n] \le e^{-n^2\log p + O(n^2/\log n)}$ for every composite $n$, without the restriction on $p$ that the case split at $\sqrt{n}$ would impose. For even $n$ the error terms are sharper: $T(n/2,2) = \binom{n}{n/2}$ (an array with $b = 2$ is determined by the set of rows that swap the blocks, which has size $n/2$), so exactly $\binom{n}{n/2}L(n/2)^4$ squares of $\mathcal{L}_n$ have all rows in $\mathrm{Stab}(\Pi)$, and by (3) with $n!/|\mathrm{Stab}(\Pi)| = \frac{1}{2}\binom{n}{n/2}$ and the asymptotics $\log L(m) = m^2\log m - 2m^2 + O(m\log^2 m)$ that (1) encodes, $\mathbb{P}[H \le \mathrm{Stab}(\Pi)] = 2^{-n^2 + O(n\log^2 n)}$; the union over the $\frac{1}{2}\binom{n}{n/2}$ partitions into two blocks changes this by $2^{O(n)}$, and the proof bounds the whole sum by $n\,e^{-n^2\log 2 + O(n\log^2 n)}$, so $\log \mathbb{P}[H \not\supseteq A_n] = -n^2\log 2 + O(n\log^2 n)$ for even $n$.

For prime $n$ every transitive group is primitive, and the primitive display of the proof gives $\mathbb{P}[H \not\supseteq A_n] \le e^{-n^2\log n + 2n^2 + O(n^{3/2}\log^3 n)}$. This too is sharp to two terms: the Cayley tables of the $(n-1)!/|\mathrm{Aut}(\mathbb{Z}_n)| = (n-2)!$ loops on $[n]$ with identity 1 that are isomorphic to $\mathbb{Z}_n$ are reduced squares with $H$ the regular cyclic group of order $n$, so by (2) and (1)

$$\mathbb{P}[H \not\supseteq A_n] \ge \frac{(n-2)!}{R(n)} = \frac{(n-2)!\,n!\,(n-1)!}{L(n)} \ge e^{-n^2\log n + 2n^2 - O(n\log^2 n)},$$

and $\log \mathbb{P}[H \not\supseteq A_n] = -n^2\log n + 2n^2 + O(n^{3/2}\log^3 n)$ along the primes.

The threshold $n \ge e^{15}$ in the proof is an artefact of the case split and has not been optimised: the sum over the divisors $a$ of $n$ of $n!\cdot n!\,(b!)^n L(a)^{b^2}/L(n)$ (the first display of the imprimitive case times the crude count $n!$ of partitions, with (1) inserted for $L(a)$ and $L(n)$ and $n!$, $(b!)^n$ exact) is already less than 1 for every composite $n \ge 93$ (and is $e^{-0.88\,n^2\log 2}$ at $n = 1000$), and with the exact van der Waerden and Brégman expressions in place of (1) and the exact number $n!/((a!)^b b!)$ of partitions in place of $n!$ it is less than 1 for every composite $n \ge 15$ ($e^{-0.37\,n^2\log 2}$

at $n = 30$, $e^{-0.70\,n^2\log 2}$ at $n = 100$). These statements are certified as follows [16]: both sums were evaluated for every composite $n \le 25000$, and for $n \ge 22107$ the two inequalities of the proof — a term with $a \ge \sqrt{n}$ is at most $-n^2\log 2 + n^{3/2}(\frac{1}{2}\log^2 n + 3\log n + 3) + 2n\log n$ and a term with $a < \sqrt{n}$ at most $-\frac{1}{4}n^2\log n + \frac{5}{2}n^2 + 2n\log n$, both decreasing in $n$ after division by $n^2$ — make every term of the first sum, hence of the second, which is termwise smaller, less than $1/n$.

*Remark* 4 (the sign). The second bound of the theorem rests on the bound of [7] for the proportion of all-even squares, which is $(\sqrt{3/4}+o(1))^n$, so $c$ can be taken to be any number above $\sqrt{3/4}$. Kwan, Petrova and Sawhney [9] have since shown that the vector of row parities of a uniformly random Latin square behaves like a vector of independent fair coin flips, in particular that the all-even proportion is at most $(\frac{1}{2}+o(1))^n$; and Greenhill, Kopfová, Kwan and Petrova [6] have now proved the matching lower bound: the all-even proportion is $(\frac{1}{2}+o(1))^n$. The sign paragraph of the proof turns this into $\mathbb{P}[H \le A_n] = 2\cdot(\frac{1}{2}+o(1))^n = (\frac{1}{2}+o(1))^n$, and since $\mathbb{P}[H \le A_n,\, H \ne A_n] \le \mathbb{P}[H \not\supseteq A_n] = e^{-\Omega(n^2)}$,

$$\mathbb{P}[H = A_n] = (\tfrac{1}{2}+o(1))^n \qquad \text{and} \qquad \mathbb{P}[H \ne S_n] = (\tfrac{1}{2}+o(1))^n,$$

both two-sided; so the exceptional loops are, to the exponential order, exactly those with $\mathrm{Mlt}_\lambda(Q) = A_n$, and in the theorem every $c > \frac{1}{2}$ works and no $c < \frac{1}{2}$ does.

*Remark* 5 (quasigroups). With $G = \langle r_1, \dots, r_n\rangle$ in place of $H$, the same three steps (Lemma 2 with $\Pi' = \Pi$, the count $|K|^n$, and [7]) reprove Cameron's theorem [3] without [10], with the same bounds: $e^{-(\log 2 - o(1))n^2}$ for $G \not\supseteq A_n$ and $3c^n$ for $G \ne S_n$. The converse direction is not available: the loop case does not follow from the quasigroup case, because the symbol relabelling that produces a reduced square replaces the row group $\langle r_i\rangle$ by $\langle r_1^{-1} r_i\rangle$.

*Remark* 6 (the primitive case). The primitive case needs only that every primitive $K \not\supseteq A_n$ has $\log|K| = o(n)$: then the generator count makes the number of such $K$ at most $(n!)^{o(n)} = e^{o(n^2\log n)}$, negligible against $L(n)/n!$. Babai's bound $B$ gives this with room to spare, and so would the bound $\exp(O(n^{1/3}\log^{7/3} n))$ of Sun and Wilmes [18], also proved without the classification, which holds for every uniprimitive group except $S_m$ and $A_m$ acting on 2-subsets of $[m]$ ($n = \binom{m}{2}$) and the primitive groups between $A_m \times A_m$ and $S_m \wr S_2$ in product action ($n = m^2$) [18, Corollary 1.3]; these exceptions are Cameron groups, of order $e^{O(\sqrt{n}\log n)}$, and the first of them shows that Babai's bound is sharp up to the power of the logarithm ($S_m$ on 2-subsets has order $m! = e^{\Theta(\sqrt{n}\log n)}$). Praeger and Saxl's elementary bound $|K| < 4^n$ [12] is too weak for the generator count (it gives $(n!)^{2n}$ subgroups). That is why a first version of this note combined it with Pyber's bound $2^{(\frac{1}{6}\log_2 24 + o(1))n^2}$ on the number of subgroups of $S_n$ [13] (recently sharpened to $2^{n^2/16 + O(n^{3/2})}$ by Roney-Dougal and Tracey [15]); we have not checked whether that count can be obtained without the classification of finite simple groups. Eberhard pointed out that the elementary order bounds of Babai and Pyber used above make the primitive case self-contained and visibly free of it.

*Remark* 7 (what is and is not used). Nothing is used about the distribution of any single row. The event $H \le K$ is the intersection of the $n-1$ events $\sigma_i \in K$, and the identity row, which defeats the one-row argument, contributes nothing to it. The crude count $|K|^{n-1}$ against $(n!)^{n-1}e^{-n^2+o(n^2)}$ already settles each individual $K$ of index at least $e^{(1+\delta)n}$; the two maximal subgroups of smaller index, $A_n$ and $S_{n/2}\wr S_2$ (with their conjugates), are where the Latin constraints inside $K$ have to be used, through [7] and through Lemma 2 respectively. In particular the theorem says nothing about the conjecture of [5] on the cycle type of the second row, which concerns one row given

the identity row, and which remains open; the consequence recorded in [5, Lemma 6.2] simply does not need it.

*Remark* 8 (Eberhard's sketch). In comments on [4] (October 2016), Eberhard observed that the number of Latin squares with all rows in $K$ is at most $|K|^n = (n!)^n/[S_n : K]^n$ against $L(n) = (n!)^n/e^{n^2+o(n^2)}$, concluded that only $A_n$ and $S_{n/2} \wr S_2$ need separate treatment, and asked whether the method of [7] adapts to other subgroups; Cameron replied that this "should not be too hard" and that the second-row conjecture was the most interesting part; Eberhard then sketched for $S_{n/2} \wr S_2$ a row-by-row count (fill the first $k \approx n/10$ rows inside the group, bound the rest by the standard row-by-row estimate). The sketch is correct once one passes to maximal subgroups, which takes care of the imprimitive groups with $b \geq 3$; what remains to be supplied is the primitive case, for which an elementary order bound for primitive groups suffices, as Eberhard pointed out to us (the sketch's "only $A_n$ and $S_{n/2} \wr S_2$" presupposes such a bound; see Remark 6), and the details for $S_{n/2} \wr S_2$. Lemma 2 treats all imprimitive groups uniformly and gives the sharp exponent. As far as we know the argument was not written out.

*Remark* 9 (small orders). For $n = 5$, of the 56 reduced squares 50 have $H = S_5$ and 6 have $H = C_5$ (the sorted Cayley table of $\mathbb{Z}_5$ for each of the six cyclic subgroups; these are also the all-even ones). For $n = 6$, of 9408 reduced squares 7776 have $H = S_6$, 72 have $A_6$ and 1560 have an imprimitive $H$ (block sizes 2 and 3, orders 6 to 48). In samples of 3000 Latin squares at each order $7 \leq n \leq 16$ produced by the Jacobson–Matthews chain [8] (the chain on proper and improper squares, started from the cyclic square, run for $200t$ moves and then recorded at those times $200t + kt$, $k \geq 1$, at which the state is proper, improper checkpoints being skipped with the grid kept, $t = 20n^2$; the stationary distribution restricted to proper states is uniform, and recording at fixed times rather than at the first proper state after a prescribed number of moves avoids a stopping-time bias, so the protocol has the right target distribution; but we have not verified mixing, so these are samples from a chain, not certified uniform samples), the number of squares with $H = A_n$ was $37, 25, 18, 4, 1, 4, 0, 1, 0, 0$ for $n = 7, \ldots, 16$, and every other $H$ was $S_n$ except for two squares at $n = 8$ with $H = S_2 \wr S_4$ (order 384) [16].

*Remark* 10 (labelled and unlabelled loops). The theorem counts labelled loops on $[n]$ with identity 1, i.e. reduced squares, and the error bound survives the passage to isomorphism classes. Let $p_n \leq 3c^n$ be the proportion of reduced squares with $H \neq S_n$ and $\varepsilon_n$ the proportion of reduced squares whose loop has a nontrivial automorphism group. A loop automorphism is an autotopism of the square, the autotopy group is an isotopy invariant, and the map from $\mathcal{L}_n$ to reduced squares is uniform, so $\varepsilon_n$ is at most the proportion of Latin squares with a nontrivial autoparatopy group, which is $n^{-3n^2/8+o(n^2)}$ by [11, Theorem 4]. An isomorphism class with trivial automorphism group contains exactly $(n-1)!$ reduced squares, and every class contains at least one, so the proportion of isomorphism classes with multiplication group $\neq S_n$ is at most $(p_n + (n-1)!\,\varepsilon_n)/(1-\varepsilon_n) = O(c^n)$: with $N = R(n)$, the classes with $H \neq S_n$ and trivial automorphism group number at most $p_n N/(n-1)!$ (the row group is an isomorphism invariant up to conjugacy, so every square of such a class has $H \neq S_n$), the classes with nontrivial automorphism group number at most $\varepsilon_n N$, and the classes with trivial automorphism group alone number $(1-\varepsilon_n)N/(n-1)!$.

Acknowledgements. We thank Sean Eberhard for the argument he sketched in 2016 and for pointing out that the elementary order bounds of Babai and Pyber make the primitive case free of the classification of finite simple groups. [Cameron; Wanless.]

## References

[1] L. Babai, On the order of uniprimitive permutation groups, *Ann. of Math.* 113 (1981), 553–568.

[2] L. Babai, On the order of doubly transitive permutation groups, *Invent. Math.* 65 (1982), 473–484.
[3] P. J. Cameron, Almost all quasigroups have rank 2, *Discrete Math.* 106/107 (1992), 111–115.
[4] P. J. Cameron, A niggling problem, blog post, 24 January 2015, with comments by S. Eberhard, 12–13 October 2016, https://cameroncounts.wordpress.com/2015/01/24/a-niggling-problem/.
[5] N. J. Cavenagh, C. Greenhill and I. M. Wanless, The cycle structure of two rows in a random Latin square, *Random Structures Algorithms* 33 (2008), 286–309.
[6] C. Greenhill, M. Kopfová, M. Kwan and K. Petrova, On the probability that a random Latin square is all-even, arXiv:2610.13487 (2026).
[7] R. Häggkvist and J. C. M. Janssen, All-even Latin squares, *Discrete Math.* 157 (1996), 199–206.
[8] M. T. Jacobson and P. Matthews, Generating uniformly distributed random Latin squares, *J. Combin. Des.* 4 (1996), 405–437.
[9] M. Kwan, K. Petrova and M. Sawhney, Parities in random Latin squares, arXiv:2509.13125 (2025).
[10] T. Łuczak and L. Pyber, On random generation of the symmetric group, *Combin. Probab. Comput.* 2 (1993), 505–512.
[11] B. D. McKay and I. M. Wanless, On the number of Latin squares, *Ann. Comb.* 9 (2005), 335–344.
[12] C. E. Praeger and J. Saxl, On the orders of primitive permutation groups, *Bull. London Math. Soc.* 12 (1980), 303–307.
[13] L. Pyber, Enumerating finite groups of given order, *Ann. of Math.* 137 (1993), 203–220.
[14] L. Pyber, On the orders of doubly transitive permutation groups, elementary estimates, *J. Combin. Theory Ser. A* 62 (1993), 361–366.
[15] C. M. Roney-Dougal and G. Tracey, Subgroups of symmetric groups: enumeration and asymptotic properties, arXiv:2503.05416 (2025).
[16] [author], `cgw-conjecture`, https://github.com/mkkinyon/cgw-conjecture, commit `1232610` (12 October 2026): the thresholds of Remark 3 are the output of `python3 s13_loopbounds.py 25000` (log `runs/s13/loops/bounds25000.log`); the samples of Remark 9 are produced by `./jm $n 3000 $((20*n*n)) $((100+n)) | python3 s13_loopgroup.py sample $n` (logs `runs/s13/loops/sample$n.log`, each recording its command) and the exact counts at $n = 5, 6$ by `python3 s13_loopgroup.py exact $n` (`exact5.log`, `exact6.log`).
[17] J. D. H. Smith, *An Introduction to Quasigroups and Their Representations*, Chapman & Hall/CRC, 2007.
[18] X. Sun and J. Wilmes, Faster canonical forms for primitive coherent configurations, in *STOC '15*, ACM, 2015, 693–702.
[19] J. H. van Lint and R. M. Wilson, *A Course in Combinatorics*, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2001.